

MAXIMUM LEADER

Her choice for the highest office in the country is not challenged by allies. Her control over the party is absolute. Her power extends beyond UPA. Her imprint is visible on policies. India's most powerful politician is getting savvier and even shedding the aura of inaccessibility.



■ By Priya Sahgal

The lady's not for turning!" That was Margaret Thatcher more than 25 years ago, in a defiant speech at the Conservative conference in Brighton. In another country, in another context, another lady—for whom iron is yet to become an adjective though—too refused to take a U-turn on an issue she thought was central to her political authority. Sonia Gandhi didn't budge on Pratibha Patil in spite of a barrage of allegations against the Congress's choice for the President. It was, in retrospect, a power parade of India's most powerful politician—and the only one who remains unchallenged within her party. As the *maximo lider* (the original one is in his autumnal disintegration in Havana) showed what she could

achieve no matter what the frustrated Opposition said about her candidate, the party or the allies or the fan club at AKG Bhavan gave her no reason for a rethink. They stood by in awe, and bowed in approval.

The Leader with a Capital L, usually a Communist reality, got its first Indian edition when Indira Gandhi was at her Mother India best. The daughter-in-law, after a tentative beginning, is almost there, though the differences are starker than the similarities. For the original Mrs G, triumph and supremacy came after struggle and isolation. Nehru's daughter had a harder time than Rajiv Gandhi's widow. Indira had to play smarter than the wily veterans of the Syndicate to take control of the party. Sonia didn't even try; there was no need to. This leader grows larger on the collective desperation—

and submission—of Congressmen. When India got its first woman President, jubilant Congress workers swarmed 10 Janpath chanting a remix of Dev Kant Barooah's infamous slogan about Indira: "Sonia is Congress and Congress is Sonia".

The mythology of Sonia the mother superior began with her melodramatic renunciation drama in the Central Hall of Parliament after the UPA victory in the last General Elections. Perhaps that was her best career move, when she said no to prime ministership. She has been slowly but steadily strengthening her position as the UPA's chief arbiter, often functioning as the conscience keeper of the Government. Swayed by the Jessica Lal murder trial, she suggested stronger witness protection measures in the Criminal Procedure Code. Her current pet pro-